Photograph by
BANDEEP SINGH

a character's skin. It has made her avoid the rigour of television and still lean to stage (she's currently touring with the Marathi play *Karunashtake*). "In TV, you don't get a lot of time," she says. "To rote and render is not my skill set." Rehearsals came in handy, especially for season five of *Gullak*, after Vaibhav Raj Gupta, who plays the Annu of 'Annu ki Mummy', quit and a familial bond needed to be established with the new actor, Anant V. Joshi. "I have never seen all actors come together and intervene to make peace between an actor [Gupta] and the company [The Viral Fever]. All of us went the extra mile," says Kulkarni. "Unfortunately, it didn't happen."

With *Maa Behen*, Kulkarni relished the "wacky characters and quirky dialogues" that writer Pooja Tolani has imagined for Suresh Triveni's film. OTTs have given Kulkarni the work she has long merited, but the space isn't as vibrant as before, she says. "I won't disagree that it has helped because otherwise we don't get screen space in theatrical films. Series are long-format and, with seasons, we are able to explore our roles deeper," she says. "But the two to three years have been difficult, opportunities have shrunk." Now, with the double bonanza of *Gullak* and *Maa Behen*, Kulkarni hopes the shoot calendar gets busy again. ■

—Suhani Singh

MUSIC ▼

Essence of India

WHAT TO EXPECT IN THE NEW SEASON OF **COKE STUDIO BHARAT**

When the Indian version of the music television programme Coke Studio—the fourth and final season of which aired in 2015—returned in 2023 as the web series *Coke Studio Bharat*, it had a fresh format too. It now comprises individual music videos by different artistes. "We've always rooted ourselves in stories of culture and stories from a particular part of the country," says Shantanu Gangane, integrated marketing experience lead at Coca-Cola for India and Southwest Asia. "That stems from various factors like the artistes we work with, the lyrics, the hidden or lost instruments [we showcase], and how we present them."

If Coke Studio@ MTV leaned on established acts, *Coke Studio Bharat* has enlisted many rising stars of the independent music scene. Season four has a couple of singers who scored two of 2025's biggest hits, Aditya Rikhari and Faheem Abdullah, the respective voices behind 'Sahiba' and the title track of *Saiyaara*.

Among the main aims of the series **has been to spotlight India's regional**-language singers and folk musicians

Among the main aims of the series has been to spotlight India's regional-language singers and folk musicians. The show has exposed to a wider audience the talents of folk music acts like Kumaoni singer Kamla Devi, Maharashtrian dhol tasha band Girgaon Dhwaj Pathak, and—this season—former factory worker-turned-Punjabi vocalist Ashok Maskeen, who contributes to Madhur Sharma's Bulleh Shah-inspired 'Bulleya Ve'.

Punjabi and Rajasthani sounds have been part of almost every season. They're back this time around, thanks respectively to 'Bulleya Ve' and the Kutle Khan-featuring 'Ae Ajnabee' by Rikhari and producer Ravator. Bhojpuri has given us the standout track of 2026 so far, 'Kachaudi Gali', a traditional tune given a twist by singer Rekha Bhardwaj, vocalist Utpal Udit and producer Khwaab. ■

—Amit Gurbaxani



WONDER ALLEY
From left, the creators of 'Kachaudi Gali': producer Khwaab, and singers Rekha Bhardwaj and Utpal Udit